

Strategy Gate Review

Ten questions somebody will eventually ask you. Better to ask them yourself, while the answer can still change.

- 1 • **Has context shaped this?** Fail: the document would work unchanged for a competitor.
- 2 • **Is the diagnosis specific and credible?** Fail: it opens with goals, or never says why the obvious answer has not already been taken.
- 3 • **Is the tension named, and is its kind named?** Fail: harmony is implied. Or a paradox has been resolved by picking a pole, which reads as decisive and throws away something needed.
- 4 • **Has direction been chosen?** Fail: every option stays open. If nothing in the document costs anybody anything, nothing has been decided.
- 5 • **Are the guardrails usable by somebody else?** Fail: interpretation depends on the author, who will not be in the room next March.
- 6 • **Has the boundary held?** Automatic fail: the document has started choosing rather than governing choices. A layout, a supplier, a sequence, a specification.
- 7 • **Does it survive stress?** Fail: the answer changes when resources tighten or the opposition moves, which means the direction was a preference.
- 8 • **Are both clocks declared?** Fail: no shelf life, so it ages quietly. Or no horizon, so it arrives after the negotiation. The horizon is set by what is moving, not by the diary.
- 9 • **Is the organisation entitled to do this?** Fail: permission is assumed, nobody can name who grants it, or the internal and external accounts are two different accounts.
- 10 • **Can it be stated plainly?** Fail: clarity needs a preamble. Problem, tension, direction, exclusion, and who said we may, in five sentences.

The record

WHICH GATE FAILED FIRST

WHAT THAT SAYS IS MISSING

WHAT WE ARE GOING BACK TO, AND WHO IS IN THE ROOM